

What Microsoft can afford to do in a monopolistic market cannot be followed by other competitors who aim to grab the regional language, or the low-end office application software market. Proprietary file formats are essential to provide software-specific features such as linking and embedding of graphical objects that are portable across platforms and software.

In a market such as India, Open Source has already had a headstart with governments and other organisations rapidly moving towards at least partial adoption of various Open Source products. The issue of ensuring compatibility therefore has the ominous makings of turning into a veritable nightmare for entrepreneurs who hope to grab the as yet untapped portions of a potentially unlimited market. Both CK Technologies and Modular InfoTech, however, claim to have solved the problem at least as far as font portability over e-mail is concerned.

It is, however, true that companies use continual innovation and support to deal with the lack of compatibility or portability. Netcore has an exclusive, 9 am to 9 pm support team of 15 engineers armed with mobile phones. Kalpit says that it is actually possible for them to provide remote support because they are using a Linux-based technology. Other than that, all Netcore products come with a utility-assisted backup application. For their Mailserver and Freedom software, Netcore provides training for EDP and IT managers for client companies. The training cost is included in the software cost.

CK Technologies is in the process of revamping their entire support process, currently based on e-mail and telephone support. By October, says Vinod Reddy of CK Tech, they intend to have a proper help-desk in place, handling calls from all parts of the country, irrespective of the language callers may speak. This will be supplemented by a revamped Web site, which will have comprehensive documentation of its software in the market.

Modular InfoTech has an e-mail and telephone call-based support system, besides arranging corporate training sessions and sending support executives over, which is charged accordingly.

That Netcore uses the Fedora core 1 for its Freedom and MailServer software, which means that they conform to a certain Open Source standard that is globally gaining acceptance. Given



Highlights Of An Office Alternative

Shakti Office 1.72

- ☑ Low memory requirement: as low as 64 MB RAM
- ☑ Single-click Menu Toggle and Typing Toggle to switch between English and Indian languages
- ☑ Transliterate from Indian languages to English and vice-versa
- ☑ Graphical User Interface Toggle - Message Box, Dialog Box in English and Regional Language
- ☑ Dictionary, spell-check, thesaurus for English and Indian languages
- ☑ Bilingual-sorting, import and export of data
- ☑ Find and Replace - (English to Indian Languages and vice-versa)
- ☑ Support for almost all of the popular standards (rtf, doc, html, xls, mdb, and many more)
- ☑ Help is available in English, Hindi, Tamil, etc
- ☑ E-mail in English and Indian languages
- ☑ Remote Help option available
- ☑ Inbuilt facility to export to PDF
- ☑ Ability to covert documents in old legacy encoding to standard encoding

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a suitable period of gestation, it can attain the level of standardisation, which will enable it to port and share its application across software or platforms that conform to that yardstick. Shakti Office plainly follows conventions and menu layouts that MS Office exhibits, and so does Ankur Office. The Microsoft imprint in form of various WYSIWYG tools is clear on screen.

It is not a drawback of such software, though, that they make use of the practicalities shown by Microsoft and other software makers in their products. As Manoj Russel, MD, CK Technologies acknowledges, "It (Shakti Office) does not claim to be an equal of MS Office. However, we ensure that it doesn't come with bloatware!"

It is just an acknowledgement of market realities. The main clientele of all the three companies are government offices, schools and other educational institutions, insurance companies and Public Sector Undertakings. Though all of them have corporate customers, it is still too early to think of them challenging the kind of turnover that even the Indian wings of multinational software companies churn in.

The Rural Business Suite

Once affordable broadband becomes a reality in India, a hundred different solutions can crop up from its hinterland, and these entrepreneurs are well on their way to use that carrier to increase PC penetration in India from its current 3 per cent.

This is what all three manufacturers tacitly agree on. "We are convinced that if IT has to reach the masses, it can only be through the use of local languages on computers. Considering the above, we decided to develop a software which is equally powerful and much more user-friendly than multinational English software and which will give you the pleasure of working in Indian languages rather than in English," says Joshi, Technical Director, Modular InfoTech.

Once the hinterland is irrigated, a billion different flowers can bloom. Computer literacy can then, seriously, give functional literacy a challenge. Whether it is a mining contractor in Jharkhand, or a date palm grower in Kerala, a paperless office does have the promise of being a working reality, and not just a pretty machine sitting in the corner challenging you to *Solitaire*. ☐

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Highlights Of An Office Alternative

Netcore Emergic Cleanmail

- ☑ Detailed reporting including usage analysis and bandwidth monitoring
- ☑ Anti-spam technology
- ☑ Three-level virus scanning
- ☑ Infrastructure: servers co-located with VSNL
- ☑ No extra cost involved, as it is a hosted service
- ☑ 24/7 tech support
- ☑ Auto-learning/keyword-based blocking
- ☑ Bundled service with hosting plans from various hosting companies